

Reading Texts in Indian English – II

[AEC] [MIL] · Semester IV

■ VVIMP Questions & Answers ■

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Subject	English – Reading Texts in Indian English II
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Type	VVIMP Questions & Answers (Exam Special)

UNIT I – POETRY

1. Hunger – Jayant Mahapatra

Q1. What is the central theme of the poem 'Hunger'?

Ans:

The central theme is **poverty, moral degradation, and exploitation**. Extreme poverty forces a father to sell his fifteen-year-old daughter's body for money. The word 'Hunger' carries a **double meaning** — physical hunger (starvation/poverty) and the narrator's sexual desire. Mahapatra powerfully shows how poverty strips away human dignity.

Q2. Who are the characters in 'Hunger' and what are their roles?

Ans:

There are three characters:

- **The Fisherman** – A desperate poor father who offers his daughter to the narrator. He represents helplessness caused by poverty.
- **The Narrator** – A traveler who follows the fisherman. He feels moral conflict and guilt.
- **The Daughter** – A fifteen-year-old girl who is a silent victim of poverty and exploitation.

Q3. Explain the significance of the title 'Hunger'.

Ans:

'Hunger' operates on two levels:

- **Physical Hunger** – The fisherman's family is so poor that he must sell his daughter to survive.
- **Sexual Hunger** – The narrator feels desire: 'I felt the hunger there, the other one.'

The title is deeply ironic — both forms of hunger lead to exploitation of the innocent.

Q4. What does the line 'The sky fell on me, and a father's exhausted wife' mean?

Ans:

'The sky fell on me' is a metaphor for **shock and overwhelming guilt** — the narrator is stunned when he hears the daughter is only fifteen. 'A father's exhausted wife' means the fisherman's last desperate trick — using his child as a means of income, not out of cruelty, but out of total exhaustion from poverty.

Q5. What is the tone and mood of 'Hunger'?

Ans:

The tone is **dark, disturbing, and guilt-ridden**. Imagery of flickering oil lamps, lean-to shacks, froth from old nets, and rubber-cold skin creates a suffocating, oppressive mood that mirrors the hopelessness of poverty.

Q6. What does 'his white bone thrash his eyes' suggest?

Ans:

This surreal image suggests **inner violence and desperation**. The fisherman is torn apart inside — his poverty and helplessness are so extreme that it shows on his face. It also indicates his sense of shame at what he is about to do.

Q7. How does Mahapatra use nature imagery in 'Hunger'?

Ans:

Mahapatra uses nature imagery to reflect the narrator's internal state:

- 'Sprawling sands' – vastness of despair
- 'Palm fronds scratched my skin' – discomfort, moral friction

- 'The wind was I' – the narrator feels as hollow and directionless as wind
- 'Fish slithering, turning inside' – a metaphor for guilt and desire churning within him

Q8. What is the social commentary in 'Hunger'?

Ans:

The poem is a **sharp criticism of extreme poverty in India**. It shows how economic deprivation destroys morality and forces parents into unimaginable acts of desperation. It also questions the silent complicity of society — represented by the narrator who does not refuse. Mahapatra condemns the exploitation of women and children in poverty-stricken communities.

2. The Right Image – Agha Shahid Ali

Q1. What is the central idea of 'The Right Image'?

Ans:

The poem explores the idea that **true images or truths are often absent or illusory**. The reflected moon in the lake does not actually exist — it is only a reflection. This represents how we often mistake illusions for reality and how the 'right image' — the true picture — is always elusive and difficult to grasp.

Q2. Explain the imagery used in 'The Right Image'.

Ans:

The poem uses three central images:

- **Lake under the heart** – an internal emotional space, a place of deep feeling within the self
- **Black swans** – dark, mysterious forces that cut through illusions
- **Moon not there** – a false image; what is reflected does not exist in reality

Together they suggest that what we perceive may be a beautiful but false reflection.

Q3. What do the 'black swans' symbolize?

Ans:

Black swans symbolize **darkness, mystery, and truth-seeking**. Unlike white swans (beauty, peace), black swans disturbing a false reflection suggest that truth, when it appears, disrupts our comfortable illusions. They are agents of reality cutting through deception.

Q4. Why does Ali say 'a moon that is not there'?

Ans:

This phrase is the philosophical core of the poem. The moon's reflection exists in the lake — but the moon itself is not visible. This is a metaphor for **false images, illusions, and deceptive appearances**. It questions: what we believe we see — is it real, or just a reflection of something absent?

Q5. What is the form and structure of 'The Right Image'?

Ans:

The poem is a **short lyric of six lines** with no rhyme scheme. Its brevity mirrors its theme — truth is not elaborate; it is simple, elusive, and hard to define. The compact structure forces the reader to pause and reflect on each image carefully.

Q6. Write a short note on 'The Right Image' by Agha Shahid Ali.

Ans:

'The Right Image' is a short but profound poem. Agha Shahid Ali presents the image of a lake beneath the poet's heart, where black swans cut through the reflection of a moon that does not actually exist. The poem deals with the theme of **illusion versus reality**. The 'right image' is the true, correct perception — which is always difficult to find because we are surrounded by reflections and false appearances. Ali uses minimalist

imagery to convey a deeply philosophical idea: that the truth we search for may not exist where we look for it.

3. Sunrise – Padma Sachdev

Q1. What is the central theme of 'Sunrise'?

Ans:

The poem uses an **extended school metaphor** to describe the natural phenomenon of a late sunrise during a stormy day. The theme is the **conflict between natural forces** presented humorously. It also carries a deeper message — questioning blind authority and whether those in power always know the true reasons behind someone's situation.

Q2. Explain the extended metaphor used in 'Sunrise'.

Ans:

Sachdev brilliantly maps a classroom onto a natural scene:

- **Sun** = late-arriving, arrogant schoolboy ('like an arrogant school boy who has been late')
- **Sky** = the strict, angry schoolmaster who writes on the blackboard
- **Clouds** = the opposing force, raining and thundering
- **Storm/Lightning** = the war/conflict in the classroom

This metaphor makes nature relatable and injects humor into an everyday observation.

Q3. What does the sun whisper to the clouds and why is it significant?

Ans:

The sun whispers to the clouds that 'there is no wisdom in underestimating the gleams of the sun, and there is no fixed time for the sun to rise.' This is significant because it is a **quiet act of defiance** — the sun asserts its independence and refuses to accept fixed rules. It suggests that **creative power (the sun's light) cannot be confined to schedules or authority**.

Q4. Explain: 'Who has given the schoolmaster so much wisdom to punish the late-comers without knowing their real reasons?'

Ans:

This is the philosophical heart of the poem. It questions **blind authority** — those who punish without understanding context or reason. The sky/teacher punishes the sun without knowing WHY it was late (because of the storm/clouds). This can be applied to society — institutions, laws, and authorities that judge and punish without empathy or proper inquiry.

Q5. How does Padma Sachdev use humor in 'Sunrise'?

Ans:

The humor comes from giving human qualities to natural elements:

- The sun arrives late and boasts 'I am here now. Let the class start.'
- Then it nervously 'tiptoed and sat in the corner of the last bench' — afraid of the teacher.
- The sky writes on a blackboard about the sun's dirty slate and pale color.

This playful, childlike humor makes the poem charming while carrying a serious message about authority.

Q6. What is the mood and tone of 'Sunrise'?

Ans:

The mood is **playful, whimsical, and lightly comic**. Sachdev treats a natural event like a school drama. The tone, however, becomes thoughtful and slightly rebellious toward the end when the sun questions the authority of the sky. The shift from humor to quiet defiance gives the poem depth.

4. The House of My Childhood – Dilip Chitre

Q1. What is the central theme of 'The House of My Childhood'?

Ans:

The poem is about **memory, loss, time, and the persistence of the past**. The poet revisits his empty childhood home — all furniture is gone except the grandmother's grindstone and brass figurines. It explores how physical places vanish but emotional memories linger. It also touches on **aging, loneliness, and the impossibility of returning to childhood**.

Q2. What are the only objects left in the house and what do they symbolize?

Ans:

Two objects remain:

- **Grandmother's grindstone** — symbolizes domestic life, hard work, tradition, and the daily rhythm of family life
- **Brass figurines of gods** — symbolizes faith, spirituality, and the grandmother's devotion

These objects are the last anchors to a life once lived — **symbols of roots and memory**.

Q3. Explain: 'After the death of all birds / Bird-cries still fill the mind.'

Ans:

This is one of the poem's most powerful lines. It means that even after **physical things disappear, their memory remains alive**. The birds are dead and gone, but their sounds echo in the mind. Similarly, the people and life of childhood have gone, yet their presence still fills the poet's consciousness. It reflects the **persistence of memory beyond physical reality**.

Q4. Who is the 'elderly infant' in the poem?

Ans:

The 'elderly infant' is the **poet himself**. He is old in years but when he enters the empty childhood home, he feels like a toddler again — helpless, lost, and overwhelmed. This paradox (old + infant) perfectly captures the **emotional regression that memory causes**: we grow old in body but become children again in our hearts when we face lost places and people.

Q5. Explain: 'Words distribute their silence / Among intricately clustered glyphs.'

Ans:

This surreal line suggests that **language fails to fully capture memory**. Words can only distribute silence — they are inadequate to express the depth of what is felt. 'Glyphs' are ancient symbols or carvings — suggesting that the memories are complex, layered, and ancient. Even language breaks down when facing the weight of childhood loss.

Q6. What is the significance of the grandmother's image in the poem?

Ans:

The grandmother's voice 'shivers on a bare branch' — a deeply moving image. The branch is bare (empty, winter, death), and her voice merely shivers (faint, barely there). She is gone, yet her presence pervades the house. The grandmother represents the **emotional core of the childhood home** — the warmth, spirituality, and tradition that once filled the space are now only faint tremors in memory.

Q7. Write a short note on 'The House of My Childhood'.

Ans:

'The House of My Childhood' by Dilip Chitre is a deeply moving poem about **memory, loss, and the passage of time**. The poet returns to his childhood home on a grey hill and finds it completely empty — only his grandmother's grindstone and brass god-figures remain. The poem moves between the physical emptiness of

the house and the vivid fullness of memory. Bird-cries still fill the mind even after all birds have died. His grandmother's voice still shivers on a bare branch. The poet describes himself as an 'elderly infant' — old in body but a child again in emotion. The poem powerfully explores how **the past lives inside us long after it has physically disappeared.**

UNIT II – PROSE

1. The Nation – Rabindranath Tagore

Q1. What is the main argument of Tagore in 'The Nation'?

Ans:

Tagore argues that **Nations are mechanical organizations of power**, not living personalities. People (as communities) are creative, diverse, and guided by inner ideals. Nations, however, are monotonous, mechanical, and destructive. Tagore warns that **Nationalism is a dangerous cult** that promotes collective selfishness, suppresses individuality, and leads civilization toward moral catastrophe.

Q2. What is the difference between 'People' and 'Nation' according to Tagore?

Category	Description
People	Living personalities — creative and diverse
Nation	Organizations of power — monotonous and uniform
People create	Literature, art, social symbols, ceremonies
Nations	Only produce and destroy; they do not create
People are guided by	Inner ideals and humanity
Nations are guided by	Selfishness, greed, and national interest

Q3. What does Tagore say about crowd psychology?

Ans:

Tagore says **crowd psychology is a blind force** — like steam or physical forces, it can generate immense power but has no moral direction. Rulers exploit it by fostering:

- Universal panic
- Unreasoning pride in one's own race
- Hatred of others

This is done through newspapers, school books, and even religious services. In a crowd, the individual stops reasoning — moral sense becomes blurred. Crowd mind is **essentially primitive**, and the Nation uses this primitive darkness to its advantage.

Q4. What does Tagore mean by 'Nationalism is the training of a whole people for a narrow ideal'?

Ans:

Tagore means Nationalism **limits human potential to one narrow goal** — the nation's power, success, and self-interest. This training suppresses universal moral values and leads to:

- Moral degeneracy
- Intellectual blindness
- Collective selfishness masked as patriotism

People begin to value national success over truth, justice, and humanity.

Q5. How does Tagore compare Nationalism to a brain disease?

Ans:

Tagore says '**the spirit of national selfishness is that brain disease of a people.**' Just as brain disease destroys the body's healing power, Nationalism destroys a society's moral restorative forces — its capacity for sympathy, cooperation, and self-sacrifice. It shows itself in 'red eyes and clenched fists' — aggression and violence — while the natural powers of harmony are shattered.

Q6. What is Tagore's view on professionalism?

Ans:

Tagore says professionalism is necessary but must not be allowed to dominate the personal man. In ancient India, professions were **social necessities first, livelihoods second** — kept within limits by social regulation. This gave individuals leisure to cultivate their full nature. Modern professionalism, however, makes men 'narrow and hard,' obsessed with success at the cost of ideals — similar to how Nationalism narrows a nation's moral vision.

Q7. What is Tagore's solution to the problem of Nationalism?

Ans:

Tagore does **not suggest replacing one system with another** — because all systems produce evil when the psychology at their root is wrong. Instead, he places faith in '**individuals all over the world who think clearly, feel noble, and act rightly.**'

He believes moral ideals spread like trees — organically, without a blueprint. True change must come from within individuals, not external institutions.

Q8. What does Tagore say about modern cities?

Ans:

Tagore says modern cities, shaped by the dominance of the Nation, look **everywhere the same — from San Francisco to London to Tokyo.** 'They show no faces but merely masks.' This dead monotony is the sign of the spread of the Nation. People become uniform, losing their distinct personalities and cultural richness under the mechanical force of nationalism.

Q9. What is the 'Cult of the Nation' according to Tagore?

Ans:

Tagore calls nationalism the 'Cult of the Nation' — a form of **professionalism applied to an entire people.** Just as professional men become narrow and hard, nations become collectively selfish and narrow. This cult is the greatest danger because it brings enormous material success, making people impatient with higher moral ideals. Greater success leads to stronger conflicts, jealousy, and hatred.

2. Unity of Mind – A.P.J. Abdul Kalam

Q1. What is the central message of Abdul Kalam's speech 'Unity of Mind'?

Ans:

The central message is that **India's transformation from a developing to a developed nation** requires the Unity of Minds of all its citizens. Kalam emphasizes that India's diversity of religion, culture, and language is its strength, but unity of purpose and action is needed to overcome poverty, terrorism, drought, and communal conflict.

Q2. What are the two visions Kalam talks about?

Ans:

First Vision: Gaining Independence — achieved through unity of minds, sacrifice, and focused effort under the leadership of Mahatma Gandhi and freedom fighters.

Second Vision: Transforming India from a developing nation to a **developed nation** through integrated action in:

- Agriculture and food processing
- Education and healthcare
- Infrastructure (power, roads, ICT)
- Critical technologies

Goal: eliminate poverty, illiteracy, and unemployment.

Q3. What does Kalam say about India's water problem and what solutions does he suggest?

Ans:

Kalam calls drought and floods a **paradox** — floods in one area while another faces drought. He proposes a **Water Mission**:

- **River networking** – connecting rivers across regions
- **Desalination** – converting seawater to potable water
- **Water harvesting** – revitalizing rural ponds
- **Water recycling**

He stresses large-scale **people's participation** from the conceptual stage itself.

Q4. What values does Kalam associate with India's civilizational heritage?

Ans:

Inspired by Mahatma Gandhi and his visit to Sabarmati Ashram, Kalam identifies India's core values:

- **Non-violence**
- **Tolerance**
- **Acceptance of all religions**
- **Search for Truth**
- **Fearlessness**

He says any act that runs counter to these values **threatens the fabric of a free India** — born from the supreme sacrifices of countless noble souls.

Q5. What does Kalam say about role models?

Ans:

Kalam notes that children often ask 'who are our role models?' He suggests:

- **Parents and teachers** must lead by example as enlightened citizens
- **Members of Parliament and Legislatures** should become role models
- Parliament should debate the vision of developed India and inspire children

He cites Gujarat's leaders — **Gandhi, Vallabhbhai Patel, and Vikram Sarabhai** — as historical examples, and urges creation of new role models from the present.

Q6. What is the significance of Kalam's visit to Sabarmati Ashram?

Ans:

Kalam visited the Sabarmati Ashram established by Mahatma Gandhi. Sitting in silence, he reflected on Gandhi's life. His dominant thought was: **'If we can go above our own personal hardships and see the problems of others and work for a larger cause, there is a natural elevation of our minds.'**

This moment reinforced his belief that tolerance and understanding others is the key to national unity.

Q7. What achievements does Kalam mention after Independence?

Ans:

Kalam mentions India's significant post-Independence achievements:

- **Agriculture** – Food production and self-sufficiency
- **Healthcare and Education** improvements

- International standing in **Pharmaceuticals, IT, Space, and Nuclear Science**
- Mass media and communication advancements

Despite these, Kalam emphasizes much more remains to be done, especially for the poor.

Q8. What does Kalam say about Jammu & Kashmir?

Ans:

Kalam firmly states that **Jammu and Kashmir is an integral part of India** — it is not an international issue. India is ready for bilateral dialogue once cross-border terrorism is completely stopped. He emphasizes the importance of ensuring the normal election process in J&K; and bringing peace to the region.

3. Sudha Murty: The Woman Who Inspires Many – Reena Shah

Q1. Who is Sudha Murty and why is she admired?

Ans:

Sudha Murty is a **writer, philanthropist, and entrepreneur** — one of the co-founders of Infosys and Chairperson of Infosys Foundation. She is admired for:

- Being India's **highest-selling female author** (95+ books in 16 Indian languages)
- Her **simple lifestyle** despite enormous wealth
- Philanthropic work in education, healthcare, and women's empowerment
- Receiving **Padma Shri** and **Padma Bhushan** (April 5, 2023, from President Draupadi Murmu)

Q2. How did Sudha Murty break gender barriers in engineering?

Ans:

Sudha was the **only female student** at B.V.B. College of Engineering, Hubli. The principal accepted her with three illogical conditions — always wear a saree, never eat in the canteen, never talk to male students. Despite this:

- She never missed a class, becoming self-sufficient
- She wrote a **bold letter to JRD Tata** protesting a job ad that said 'women need not apply'
- She was hired as **Tata Motors' first female engineer**

Her courage is a landmark moment in India's gender equality journey.

Q3. What is the Infosys Foundation and what does it do?

Ans:

The **Infosys Foundation** was established by Sudha Murty in **1996** as the philanthropic wing of Infosys Technologies. Its work includes:

- **Healthcare** – building hospitals across India
- **Education** – building schools for underprivileged children
- **Rural Development** – community centers
- **Women's Empowerment** – fighting gender inequality
- **Poverty Alleviation** – working with marginalized communities

Q4. What is the significance of the thanksgiving ceremony of 3,000 sex workers?

Ans:

After **18 years of tireless work** to rehabilitate sex workers, 3,000 of them — now leading normal lives — held a thanksgiving ceremony for Sudha Murty. She was overwhelmed with emotion and quoted a shloka from Ramayana:

'God, don't make me rich or beautiful or a queen. Give me a soft heart and a strong hand so I can wipe the tears of others.'

This moment gave her profound peace and reaffirmed her life's purpose. It is her most defining moment.

Q5. What is Sudha Murty's philosophy of life?

Ans:

Her philosophy is '**Simple living and high thinking.**' Key beliefs:

- Don't be carried away by power or money
- Enjoy small things and work with honesty
- Physical seva (service) is greater than giving money
- True success means adding value to others' lives
- 'Money always changes hands — giving back to society fosters significant goodwill'

Her simplicity in dress, habits, and values stands in sharp contrast to her enormous wealth and influence.

Q6. Describe Sudha Murty's educational background.

Ans:

- **B.E. in Electrical and Electronics Engineering** – B.V.B. College of Engineering & Technology, Hubli (now KLE Technological University)
- **M.E. in Computer Science** – Indian Institute of Science (IISc), Bangalore, 1974

She was a top student in both degrees. She went on to work at Tata Motors as their first female engineer, and later met Narayana Murty there — her future husband and co-founder of Infosys.

Q7. What is the message of the essay 'Sudha Murty: The Woman Who Inspires Many'?

Ans:

The essay by Reena Shah conveys that **true success is not measured by wealth or fame, but by the difference you make in others' lives.** Sudha Murty — despite being among the richest women in India — lives simply, serves tirelessly, and writes prolifically. Her life teaches:

- Hard work and honesty pay in the long run
- Gender bias can be challenged with courage and conviction
- Giving back to society is a moral responsibility

She is a role model for women, writers, entrepreneurs, and philanthropists alike.

Q8. Write a short note on Sudha Murty as a writer.

Ans:

Sudha Murty is a **prolific author with over 95 books in 16 Indian languages.** She is India's highest-selling female author. Her books cover societal and civic issues while also entertaining and educating readers of all ages. They are known for their simplicity, humor, and universal appeal. She has received many awards including the Rajyaprashasti and six honorary doctorates from universities across India. Her writing reflects her core values — honesty, compassion, and the dignity of the ordinary person.

QUICK REVISION – IMPORTANT FACTS AT A GLANCE

Hunger – Mahapatra	Theme: Poverty & exploitation Double meaning of hunger 3 characters: fisherman, narrator, daughter
The Right Image – Ali	Theme: Illusion vs Reality Lake, black swans, absent moon Short 6-line lyric
Sunrise – Sachdev	Theme: Blind authority School metaphor: sun=late student, sky=teacher Humor + defiance
The House – Chitre	Theme: Memory & loss Objects: grindstone, brass figurines 'Elderly infant' = poet himself
The Nation – Tagore	People vs Nation Nationalism = brain disease Solution: clear-thinking individuals Crowd = blind force
Unity of Mind – Kalam	Second Vision: developed India Water Mission: river networking Values: Gandhi's legacy 55th Independence Day speech
Sudha Murty – Shah	Padma Bhushan 2023 Infosys Foundation 1996 95+ books, 16 languages First female TELCO engineer Simple living, high thinking

■ **Exam Tips:** Tagore aur Kalam — long answers madhe pakke yetil. Poetry madhye Hunger aur House of My Childhood most important. Sudha Murty facts: Padma Bhushan 2023 | Infosys Foundation 1996 | TELCO first female engineer. Short notes sathi poet/author chi background aani central theme remember kara. All the best!

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